

How Search Engines Work

Crawling, indexing, ranking and the modern results page

Crawling: how pages are discovered

- Googlebot finds URLs through links and sitemaps.
- robots.txt can stop a URL from being crawled, but not from being indexed if other sites link to it.
- Pages rendered with JavaScript are queued for rendering, which can delay indexing.

Serving and ranking

- Relevance: does the page answer this exact query?
- Quality: is it helpful, accurate and trustworthy (E-E-A-T)?
- Usability: does it load fast and work on a phone?

The modern results page

- AI Overviews cite pages that answer clearly and are trusted.
- FAQ rich results are now limited to authoritative government and health sites (since 2023).
- HowTo rich results were retired in 2023.

Indexing: understanding and storing pages

- Canonicalisation picks one URL to represent a group of duplicates.
- A noindex tag removes a page from results; it must stay crawlable for Google to see the tag.
- Being indexed does not guarantee ranking.

Search intent

- Informational: learn something ("what is SEO").
- Navigational: reach a known site ("MTN Uganda login").
- Commercial: compare options ("best laptops for students 2026").
- Transactional: act now ("buy Samsung A15 Kampala").

The three stages of Google Search

Stage	What happens	What you control
Crawling	Googlebot discovers and downloads pages	Internal links, XML sitemap, robots.txt, server speed
Indexing	Content is rendered, analysed and stored	Unique content, canonical tags, noindex, structured data
Serving	Pages are ranked for each query	Relevance to intent, content quality, page experience

Ranking factor myths vs reality

Claim	Reality
Meta keywords help rankings	Google has ignored the meta keywords tag since 2009.
Longer content always ranks higher	Length helps only when the topic needs it; intent match matters more.
Submitting to Google weekly speeds ranking	Resubmitting changes nothing; good internal links and sitemaps do.
Social media likes are a direct ranking factor	They are not; they can drive links and brand searches indirectly.

Remember

- If Google cannot crawl a page, nothing else you do for it matters.
- Indexed is not the same as ranked: quality and intent decide position.
- Always check the live results page before choosing what kind of content to create.

Watch: Introducing How Search Works — Google Search Central — <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=5MIAugQ17ks>